when the Ajmer plunder arrived. Despite – or perhaps because of – the considerable time that both Juzjani and his father Maulana Siraj-i Minhaj spent at Firuzkuh, the author provided no precise description of the site. In fact, his mentions of the city seem to "verge on the incredible" and "result in a conflated account of a capital …" when compared with the recent archaeological work at the site, as discussed further on.[11]

In light of the role played by architecture – particularly palatial architecture – throughout the Persianate ecumene until the late eighteenth century,[12] the dissonance between *Tabaqat*'s formulaic descriptions of the site and its archaeology are, in fact, not surprising. Chapter 1, argued that, for pre-modern power-seeking elites, architectural patronage was an important means of labor mobilization, and the resulting structures also served as monumental markers of territory and as effective tools for the establishment of bases of socio-cultural power. In short, architectural activity was instrumental in the creation of an empire, as further discussed in Chapter 4.

But for pre-modern Persian authors, their patrons, and their audiences, the palace complex was both a symbol of royalty as well as "a special place as a nexus of power which join[ed] the human and the cosmic … a symbol of something beyond the merely material." The palace had a "rhetorical function … through its affect, [which was] as essential as its residential, administrative, productive, and ceremonial functions."[13] Thus, like the poetic-literary, religious and other intellectual luminaries gracing royal courts, patronage of palaces also provided one of the many manifestations of royal prerogative and power. Indeed, Juzjani's descriptions of Firuzkuh's buildings contain many elements directly echoed in *qasida*s (panegyric Persian poems) of the late eleventh–twelfth centuries, whose metaphorical flourishes help us not so much to "see" palaces as perceive what they *meant*.[14]

As might be expected, then, Firuzkuh's archaeology does not corroborate Juzjani's descriptions. Instead of a grand *qasr* commanding the center of Firuzkuh, it is the preponderance of defensive, religious, and possibly commercial buildings that has been archaeologically attested. It was partially this textual–archaeological discrepancy, along with other historical preconceptions, that had resulted in grave doubts about Jam-Firuzkuh as the Shansabanis' summer "capital."[15] But the work of Dr. David Thomas and the Minaret of Jam Archaeological Project (MJAP) between 2003 and 2005 have further eroded lingering skepticism of Jam-Firuzkuh as the Shansabanis' *sard-sir* destination. Even with limited time and curtailed resources, Thomas and his colleagues conducted excavations, surveys, soundings and analyses – the last also encompassing the finds from the staggering number of robber holes marking the site's mountainous terrain. Indeed, MJAP's (ongoing) studies, together with continuing anthropological research on nomadic and transhumant populations, and the con-